Coloniality, according to Quijano, is the totalising thought behind colonialism, which monopolises time, space and subjectivity, and makes all of them the exclusive preserve of the European coloniser. Quijano and other scholars, such as Sylvia Wynter, Walter D. Mignolo, Catherine E. Walsh, Nelson Maldonado-Torres and Ramón Grosfoguel, have contributed to the scholarship on the pathology of coloniality, its universalist claims and its all-pervasive character. Not only did they analyse the problem, they offered an option/alternative, namely decoloniality, which moved away from the model presented by the postmodern and postcolonial schools. Decoloniality has been described as the movement for reclamation and restoration of indigeneity and its subjectivities. In hindsight, it could be said that the existence of omnipresent coloniality and the constantly shrinking space for indigeneity meant that at some point indigeneity would resist and talk back to coloniality, and seek to reclaim its consciousness and space. However, since it took several decades after decolonisation for the natives to find their voice and speak the language of decoloniality, it is important to understand the true nature of coloniality, its motivations, underpinnings, invisible yet ever-present devices and its impact on the entirety of indigenous worldviews. Not only would this help us understand the ‘why’ of decoloniality, it would also help us make sense of the ‘how’, rather a plurality of them.

On this front, Quijano’s work represents the early pioneering years of the scholarship on coloniality when its primary focus was the colonial character of European power. Quijano was of the view that race was central to European coloniality and that there was an inextricable link between European/Western coloniality and modernity/rationality. He consciously used Europe and the West interchangeably owing to the European foundations of the Western worldview and civilisation. His diagnosis was that race consciousness and the introduction of the ‘cultural complex’ of modernity/rationality were the twin pillars of European coloniality or simply coloniality. These observations and propositions were based on his critical examination of the impact of European colonialism and coloniality on the societies and cultures of what is known as Latin America today. He identified that the relationship between European colonisers and the colonised societies of Latin America was one of ‘direct political, social and cultural domination’, which he called ‘Eurocentered colonialism’. The European coloniser consciously believed in the ‘biological and structural